Cat Crusher

Short manual . free and open source (AGPL-3.0-or-later) . github.com/SpeakingColors

Cat Crusher is a distortion, filter and compressor in one plugin. It makes drums, bass and leads thicker, grittier and louder: choose one of ten distortion types, add a hard digital crunch with Mech, tame the highs with a resonant 24 dB filter, then glue everything with a one-knob compressor. Built for dance, house, UK hardcore and hardstyle.

Quick start

- Pick the preset closest to your sound (Fat Bass, Hardstyle Kick Crunch, UK Hardcore Stab, Gritty Drums).
- Set Type first, then raise Drive until it sounds right; the Distortion curve shows the shape you are using.
- Use Cutoff to remove harsh highs, Amount for density, and Mix for parallel crush.
- Compare with the plugin bypassed and set Volume so both are equally loud.

How the window works

- Each knob sits directly under the display it changes; the displays react to the knobs and the knobs react to the displays.
- Meters show the real signal in dB with a dB scale: input and output on the far right.
- Hover a control for about one second to see an info bubble. Turn bubbles off with the round i button in the header.
- The Limiter switch in the header adds a safety limiter at the output (useful while experimenting).
- Presets are in the header; the dice picks random settings (some controls are excluded on purpose).

Controls

Distortion

Distortion	Choice: Off / On (default On)	Distortion on/off.
Type	Choice: Tube, Soft Sat, Transistor, Tape, Diode, Hard Clip, Fuzz, RAT, Overdrive, Rectifier (default Tube)	Distortion type. Tube: warm even harmonics. Soft Sat: smooth and symmetric, great on buses. Transistor: console-style, punchy and forward. Tape: gentle and rounded. Diode: edgy and asymmetric. Hard Clip: tight, loud and aggressive. Fuzz: thick, gated and woolly. RAT: hard-clipped, gritty distortion pedal style. Overdrive: smooth, mid-forward tube-pedal style. Rectifier: adds a bright octave-ish edge.
Drive	0 to 100 % default 30 %	Drive: how hard the selected distortion type is pushed. Higher = more saturation and harmonics.
Mech	0 to 100 % default 0 %	Mech: harder, more aggressive digital-style crunch (folds and clips the wave). 0 = off.

Filter

Filter	Choice: Off / On (default On)	Filter on/off.
Cutoff	40 to 20000 Hz default 20000 Hz	Cutoff: frequency of the 24 dB low-pass filter. Rolls off the harsh highs that distortion creates.
Res	0 to 100 % default 10 %	Resonance: boosts the frequencies right at the cutoff for a vocal or squelchy edge.

Compressor

Compressor	Choice: Off / On (default On)	Compressor on/off.
Phat mode	Choice: Off / On (default Off)	Phat mode: adds low-end weight before the compressor, a slower release and a soft ceiling. Great on kicks and bass.
Amount	0 to 100 % default 30 %	Compressor amount: lowers the threshold and raises the ratio together (and adds make-up gain). More = denser and louder.

Master

Volume	-24 to 12 dB default 0 dB	Volume: final output level. Match it to the bypassed level when comparing.
Mix	0 to 100 % default 100 %	Mix: dry/wet blend. Lower values keep the original punch (parallel crush).

Recommendations

- Kick: Type Diode or Transistor, Drive 60 to 80, Phat mode on, Mix 80 to 90 to keep the click.
- Bass: Type Transistor, Drive 50, Cutoff 4 kHz, Phat mode on; keep Mech low so the sub stays clean.
- Lead or stab: Mech 30 to 60 and Resonance 30 to 50 for screech; roll Cutoff down if it gets harsh.
- Drum bus: Type Tape, Drive 20 to 30, Amount 25 to 40, Mix 100 for glue or 60 to 70 for parallel punch.
- If it sounds louder but worse, lower Volume: loudness fools the ear.

Presets

Init, Warm Bus, Gritty Drums, Fat Bass, Radio Crush, Screech Lead, Hardstyle Kick Crunch, UK Hardcore Stab, Smooth Lows, Mech Mayhem

Install and use

- Windows: run the installer (.exe). macOS: open the installer (.pkg or .dmg). Linux: install the Flatpak with `flatpak install --user` and the .flatpak file, or copy the .vst3 folder to ~/.vst3.
- Everything works offline. Rescan plugins in your DAW, then look for the plugin under SpeakingColors.
- Report problems or ideas on the GitHub page of the plugin. Free to use, copy and change under the AGPL-3.0-or-later licence.